



Did you Know?

There is a parasite that can take over a spider's brain and control it. Read more : <http://digit.in/1EWJxOW>



Course Correcting Bullets!

DARPA is working on a bullet that can correct its course when misfired. <http://digit.in/1Ee1mYn>

Media streamers

Love them or hate them, you just can't live without them. Anymore.

Agent 001
agent001@digit.in

Whether it's making a dumb television smart or simply pushing onto its big screen off your connected devices, the ubiquity and convenience of media streamers can't be ignored anymore. I remember a time not too long ago when playing digital media through your television required you to jump through several taxing hoops. Not anymore. Times have changed and TVs these days support USB based digital media playback or one through HDMI, for that matter. Streaming, slinging, flinging, casting, airplay-ing media files



straight from a mobile device or any other medium is the name of the game.

Size no bar

Right now these streaming receivers come in all shapes and sizes, from slim sticks that resemble a USB pen drive (powered through a micro-USB cable) to slightly larger ones capping out at lunchbox sized streaming players that draw power through the wall socket and need more juice to work with. Larger streamers have a lot more connectivity options and their antenna is capable of better range. Also,

high-powered SoCs can run without being underclocked on boxes while the sticks are generally limited to 600 MHz or so.

Pay attention to protocols

Miracast has been around for quite a long time and has been integrated into Android 4.2+ and Windows 8.1, but there is this major drawback while playing media off the internet on your mobile device which is then Miracast to your TV – not enough bandwidth. Airplay is more intelligent in fetching media making it less prone to losing packet data – but it's only restricted to Apple devices for now. DLNA is still the way to go, the protocol is a lot more standardised so you can expect two devices that support it to work without any quirks, unlike Miracast. DIAL (Discovery And Launch) is a relatively new protocol developed by YouTube and Netflix which seems to be dying off; mDNS (Multicast Domain Name System) which works in a similar fashion seems to be rising up from DIAL's ashes. Ultimately, I believe hosting a media server is the most convenient way to stream media across multiple devices because pretty much every platform has an app.

Playing field

There's plenty of streamers to pick and choose from. Recently, I've tried the Roku Streaming Stick 3500R, Google's Chromecast and quite a lot of EZCast based dongles. Ematic's Mediabeam, Merlin-Digital's Screencast and Cubetek Air Streamer are also right up there, so is Amazon's Fire TV Stick and the recently launched Teewe 2 which sells for just ₹2,399 and plays all kinds of formats like MP4, MP3, AVI, JPEG, PNG, MKV, AVI, FLV like a charm.



Android devices generally have Miracast support without requiring any external apps